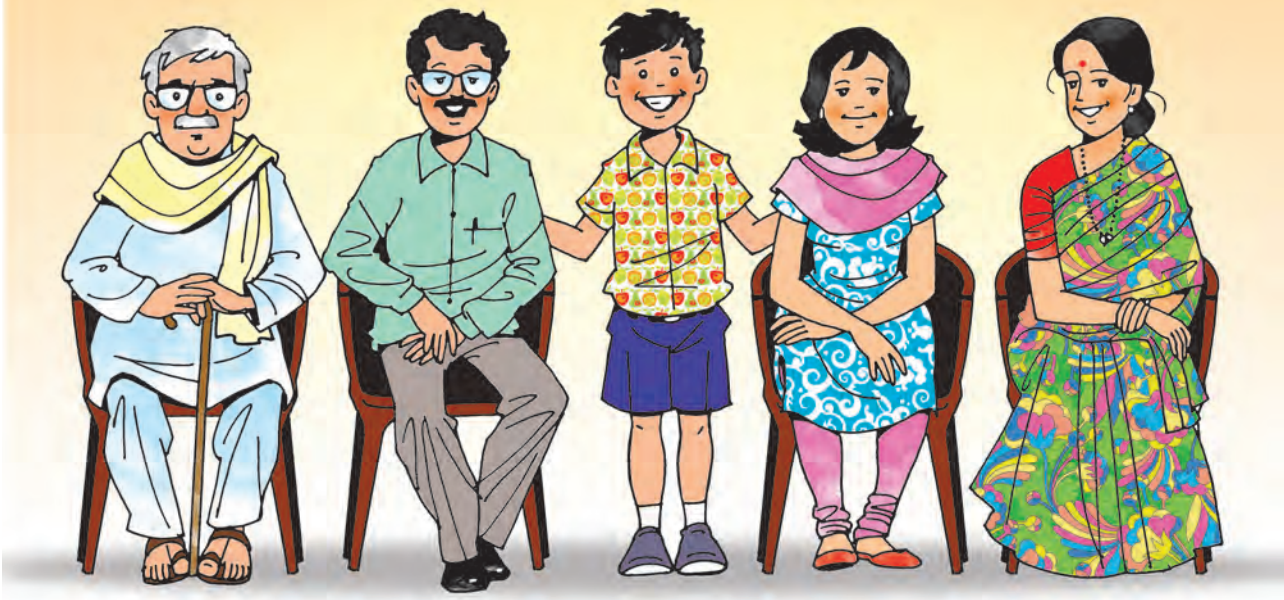
23. Growing Up and Growing Old

Can you tell ?

- What is the boy's mother in this picture wearing ?
- What is his sister wearing ?
- What is the colour of his grandfather's shirt ?
- What is the colour of his father's shirt ?



- How did you guess who the mother is and who the sister is ?
- How did you guess who the grandfather is and who the father is ?

Can you tell ?

Talk to the grown-ups to find out the following :

- When does a baby start holding up its head ?
- When does a baby start teething ?
- When do babies begin to turn over ?
- When do babies learn to stand up ?
- Why aren't newborn babies fed rice ?
- Why do small babies need to be carried ?

As we grow : A little baby is born. Everyone is happy. The mother lovingly takes care of her baby. She bathes the baby every day. She feeds it milk when it is hungry. She sings it to sleep with lullabies. Slowly, the baby grows. It becomes taller. Its weight also increases.

As the baby grows up, it learns to crawl. Its teeth come out one by one. Then it learns to stand and, later, to walk. All this while, it gains in height and weight.

The baby learns to recognize its mother. It learns to recognize other people. It begins to have other foods. Mother feeds the baby rice with milk. Gradually, it begins to speak. Whether it is a boy or girl, Nature does not differentiate between the two in their growth. When they become bigger, they are not babies any longer. A little boy becomes a big boy. A small girl becomes a big girl.

At the age of six, children start school. They keep growing in height until the age of eighteen.

Until forty years of age, a person remains fit. There is no gain in height but weight keeps increasing. Good habits and good food help to maintain good health. We benefit from regular exercise.

Even after forty years of age, there are changes in our body. Gradually, eyesight becomes weak, hair starts turning gray.

In old age, the body's strength decreases further. Hearing and memory become weaker. Teeth begin to fall. We sleep less and develop various disorders.

One day, death occurs.

Do you know ?

- A baby is given vaccines to prevent the diseases it may contract later.
- Certain vaccines have to be given at certain stages of growth. It is important to give every child, the proper vaccinations.

Can you tell ?

These are three pictures of the same mango tree. Which is the oldest picture? Which picture is the most recent? Which picture is the one of the time in between? How did you guess?

• Growth of plants

Just as people change over a period of time, so do plants. When a seed sprouts, or germinates, a new plant is produced. For the sprout to grow, it must take root in the soil. Only then does the seedling that grows from the sprout flourish.

The seedling absorbs water and some nutritious substances from the soil. The leaves begin to make food. The plant begins to grow. It gives out new leaves. It also begins to grow taller.

At the proper stage of its growth, the plant begins to flower. Fruits develop from flowers. These fruits have seeds. From those seeds, new plants grow.

A new term :

Germination : The sprouting of seeds is also known as germination.

A tree must withstand the sun, wind and rain all the time. Sometimes, it is attacked by pests. This makes the tree weaker. At last, the tree trunk breaks. The tree falls down.

All plants die. However, the causes are different.

What we have learnt –

- There are certain stages of the growth and progress of a baby.
- A person continues to grow till the age of eighteen.
- After forty years of age, a person approaches old age.
- Changes take place in plants with time, just as they do in people.
- Starting from germination in the soil, there are definite stages of the growth of plants. Plants also grow in height and strength.
- Animals or plants, all come to an end eventually.

Always remember –

A proper diet and regular exercise are necessary for keeping good health.

Exercises

A. How will you guess ?

You want to guess whether a stranger is older or younger than your parents.

B. Think and tell.

(1) How does a cat move her kittens from one place to the other?

(2) Grandfather's hair turns white. Some old men show another sign of old age on their heads. What is it?

(3) How does old age affect the skin?

(4) Beans like moong, matki and chawali sprout after being soaked in water. What other word will you use to describe this process?

C. Draw a picture.

- Draw a picture of the fruits and seeds of a pea plant.

D. Find the information and share it with the rest of the class.

- Take a fruit of any of these plants: mango, chikoo, lemon, amla, tamarind or beans. Draw its picture and colour it. Study the number of seeds it contains and write the number under the picture. Share the information you have obtained with the rest of the class.

E. Fill in the blanks.

(1) When a baby is born, everyone is ..... .

(2) Regular ..... has its advantages.

(3) ..... develop from flowers.

F. Answer in brief.

(1) Until how many years of age do children continue to grow?

(2) How can good health be maintained?

(3) When do plants begin to flower?

G. True or false ?

(1) As a baby grows, its height and weight also grow.

(2) A plant can grow even if the sprout doesn't take root in soil.

(3) The seedling absorbs water and some nutritious substances from the soil.

Activity

In a pot, sow the seeds of a plant of your choice. Observe its growth. Every Sunday, draw a picture of the plant according to your observations.